

CORE FORMULA

Assume a reasonable reason + name the observable issue + invite correction or a next step. -> I'm assuming [reasonable reason / good intent / constraint], and I noticed [observable issue]. Can we [check / decide / repair / agree a next step]? -> I may be wrong, but I'm reading this as [benign interpretation], not [negative interpretation]. Is that right? -> My guess is [charitable reason]. If that's off, correct me - what happened? -> Minimum viable: "I'm assuming there's a reasonable reason. Can you walk me through it?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Notice the ambiguity, choose the most plausible benign reading, say it in one light sentence, ask for the missing context, then respond to the facts: "I'm assuming there's a reasonable reason. Can you walk me through it?"

BEST FOR

- A missed reply or deadline where the reason is unknown.
- A blunt message that may be compressed rather than hostile.
- A disagreement where the person may be protecting a valid concern.
- High-pressure work where assumptions can quickly become blame.
- Early conflict and cross-functional friction.
- Customer support and family logistics where intent is easy to misread.
- Digital messages where tone is hard to read.

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Starter one-liners

- "I'm assuming there's a reasonable reason. Can you walk me through it?"
- "I might be reading this generously, but I'm guessing there's a reason. Can we check what happened?"
- "My guess is there's more to this. What actually happened?"
- "I'd rather ask than assume the worst - what's going on?"
- "I'm reading this charitably. Correct me if I'm off."
- "Before I jump to conclusions, give me the context?"
- "I'm assuming there's a story here I'm missing."

Charitable readings · Benign interpretations

- "I'm guessing you were trying to keep this simple."
- "I imagine time was tight."
- "This may be a crossed-wire thing rather than a real disagreement."
- "I can see you were trying not to make it heavier."
- "I'm assuming you were trying to be efficient, not dismissive."
- "I'm not reading this as you not caring."
- "I'd bet good intentions got tangled up in a busy week."
- "I'm assuming there's a reason that makes sense from where you're sitting."

Work and decisions · Professional context

- "I'm assuming this was a bandwidth issue rather than a priority call. Where does it stand now?"
- "I'm reading this as a constraint, not resistance. What constraint should we solve for?"
- "I'm assuming the team had a reason for that trade-off. Can you talk me through it?"
- "I'm assuming there's a process reason behind that. Let me check before I give a firm answer."

- "I'm assuming everyone's trying to protect the outcome. What's the clean next step?"
- "I'm assuming the escalation pulled you away, not a change in priorities."
- "I'm assuming this got crowded out rather than dropped. Can we reset the deadline?"

Assumption plus ask · Name the issue, then check

- "I'm assuming this got crowded out rather than ignored. Can we reset the deadline now?"
- "I'm reading this as risk protection, not obstruction. What risk are you seeing?"
- "I'm assuming this was a miss rather than neglect. Let's check what safeguard failed."
- "I'm assuming you're trying to solve this quickly. I need two minutes of listening before solutions."
- "I'm assuming there's a reason for the approach. Can you walk me through the thinking?"
- "I may be wrong, but I'm reading this as a timing problem, not a commitment one. Is that right?"
- "My guess is the brief was unclear. If that's off, tell me what actually happened."

Digital / text · Tone-over-text

- "Tone's hard over text, so I'm assuming this is concise rather than sharp. Fair?"
- "Reading that as brief, not blunt - let me know if I've got it wrong."
- "Hard to read tone here, so I'm assuming good faith. What did you need?"
- "I'm taking that as shorthand, not shortness."
- "No tone in text, so I'm assuming you're just busy. All good?"

When it lands wrong · Softened too much

- "I may have softened that too much. The issue is still real."
- "I may have read that too generously. Let me name the impact directly."
- "Let me correct that. I don't know your intent - I can name the impact more clearly."
- "I was trying not to assume the worst, but I hear it sounded like I was excusing it."
- "That assumption may be wrong. What was actually happening for you?"
- "I don't want to put words in your mouth. How would you describe it?"

After a pattern · Charity has run out

- "I do not want to assume the worst, and I also need this to stop."
- "I gave the benefit of the doubt; now we need a clear agreement."
- "I'm going to be more direct, because this has repeated."
- "I do not want to assume the worst, and this is now a repeated issue. I need it to change."
- "I've assumed good reasons a few times now. This time I need a firm commitment."
- "I'm not questioning your intent. I am telling you the impact has to change."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: You ignored the deadline.
Better: Maybe you were busy, but the deadline passed.
Best: I'm assuming this got crowded out rather than ignored. Can we reset the deadline now?
- Weak: That message was rude.
Better: I'm sure you didn't mean it badly.
Best: Tone's hard in chat, so I'm reading it as brief rather than hostile. Can you clarify what you need?
- Weak: You're blocking this.
Better: I guess you have concerns.
Best: I'm reading this as risk protection, not obstruction. What risk are you seeing?
- Weak: That was careless.
Better: Maybe it was an accident.
Best: I'm assuming this was a miss rather than neglect. Let's check what safeguard failed.

DECISION TREE

If Is there immediate risk or harm?

Don't soften - set a boundary or escalate.

"This needs to stop now; I'll come back to the context later."

If Is the behaviour genuinely ambiguous?

Use positive assumption.

"I'm assuming there's a reasonable reason. Can you walk me through it?"

If Is this a clear pattern after prior requests?

Use a direct request, boundary, or consequence.

"I've given the benefit of the doubt before; this time I need a firm commitment."

If Is someone voicing a concern?

Validate the concern before assuming intent.

"That worry makes sense - let me make sure I understand it before we move on."

If Did your assumption land as minimising?

Recover with intent-impact separation.

"I may have softened that too much. The impact still needs addressing."

If Did they accept the frame and explain?

Move to a concrete next step.

"Thanks - let's agree what happens next."

SCENARIOS

Missed deadline

Assume bandwidth or constraint, then reset the next action. — "I'm assuming this slipped because the week got crowded, not because it stopped mattering. What's the realistic reset?"

Blunt message

Assume compression before hostility, then ask for intent. — "Tone's hard in text, so I'm reading that as brief rather than sharp. Are you asking for a decision today?"

Team resistance

Assume risk protection, then identify the risk. — "I'm reading the pushback as risk protection, not blocking. What risk are you trying to keep us from missing?"

Family logistics

Assume overload before carelessness. — "I'm guessing this got lost in a busy day. Can we decide who owns it now?"

Customer complaint

Assume the frustration has a valid trigger, then investigate. — "I'm assuming something in the process made this harder than it should be. Let me check what happened."

Boundary repeat

Start direct; don't keep assuming positively after a pattern. — "I don't want to assume the worst, and this is now a repeated issue. I need it to change."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Repeated breaches after you have already asked directly.
- Abusive, discriminatory, coercive, or unsafe behaviour.
- When a harmed person needs you to name the impact plainly first.
- When the assumption would sound like minimising or excuse-making.
- A power imbalance where softening would protect the wrong person.
- When you already know the answer and the assumption would be a pretence.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the ambiguity

Collect five real moments this week where you assumed the worst. For each, write the observable fact separately from the story you added about their intent.

Day 2 — Rewrite the blame

Take ten blame statements ("You ignored my message", "They obviously don't care", "You forgot again") and convert each into an "I'm assuming..." line with one concrete question.

Day 3 — Under pressure

Give yourself five seconds per scenario. Keep every assumption under fifteen words before the question, so it still works when you're annoyed.

Day 4 — Calibrate

For each rewrite, write one cue that means keep going and one cue that means stop softening and name the issue directly.

Day 5 — Recover

Practise the repair out loud - "I may have softened that too much. The issue is..." - until it sounds calm rather than defensive.

Day 6 — Chain it

Add a clean request, summary check, or boundary after each assumption so it never dead-ends in vague niceness.

Day 7 — Live rep

In one real, low-stakes conversation, catch an ambiguous moment and use a single positive assumption. Note whether they relaxed, explained, or corrected you.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I separate the observable behaviour from my story about their intent?
- Was the assumption plausible and respectful, not fake or flattering?
- Did I leave room for correction and move into a concrete next step?
- Did I avoid minimising the impact on anyone who was affected?
- Did I stop softening once the behaviour was repeated or harmful?
- Did I recover cleanly when the assumption turned out to be wrong?